

In the north any attempts to improve the moral, social and physical life of the African will prove abortive. Home life will cease to exist; all belief in the sanctity of marriage will disappear. Immorality will be the rule. In consequence, venereal disease will affect 100 per cent of our native population. The birth rate will fall. Large tracts of land will be rendered unfit for habitation and in consequence the economic life of the country will suffer seriously. And, resident chiefly in other lands, the Nyasaland-born natives will have acquired a complete mistrust in and loathing for administration by the white people which has made a wilderness and called it peace (Nyasaland 1936, p. 37).

The Committee recommended more research into the problem, and as a result Read came to Nyasaland in 1939 to investigate the effects of emigration on these societies. She studied the Ngoni and Cewa of the Northern and Central Provinces which ended with 112,765 men absent from the Protectorate. Her conclusion was that traditional life was changing, but that emigration was only one of the many factors involved. Read found that matrilineal groups did not stand the strain of absent men as well as patrilineal societies, except when favored with exceptional leaders (Read 1942, p. 625).

William Watson's study (1958) of the Mambwe supported Read's opinion by showing that because the basic village groups of men were related patrilineally and agriculture actually thrived in conjunction with the migrant system. In the Mambwe, some patrilineal groups in Malawi have developed a system whereby men go south in rotation so there are always males left at home. Patrilineal societies such as the Ngoni and Tumbuka have heavy social obligations, especially during marriage, and also happen to live in the less developed part of the country. Young men have had to emigrate in order to earn the money they will need to support their families after marriage. Patrilineally a brother-in-law will provide for a woman's physical needs while her husband is away or marry her if her man stays away too long (Interview 1972). Van der Westhuis (1960) on the Lakeside Tonga (who may be either patrilineal or matrilineal) makes a convincing case for the soundness of that society although Pachai indicated that many Tonga never returned from abroad (1968, p. 8).

There is some evidence that matrilineal groups as well can tolerate missing men. Referring to the Bemba, Audrey Richards has stated that although any loss of men is serious, "There seems no doubt that women deserted for months or even years by their husbands are more happily placed in a matrilineal community than a patrilineal one" (1939, p. 131). M. G. Marwick has suggested that Cewa society, matrilineal and matrilocal in structure, was well adapted to a high labor migration because of its "extreme consanguineal organization" (1965, p. 261). Newlynweds in the wife's family's village, and the husband is expected to help cultivate the wife's garden. The wife's mother's brother claims authority over any off-lying garden. In this kind of a situation independent work abroad might be used to maintain a man's self-respect. Money sent home could be used to hire some work in the garden during the migrant's absence; returning home a rich man and money and gifts for all would increase his status with his relatives. While